Russian authorities avoided a severe balance of payments and banking crisis by allowing the ruble to float, keeping credit markets open, and buying back foreign exchange debt. These moves helped ensure macroeconomic stability was restored without a deepening of the crisis and depletion of Russia's reserves. Moreover, by blocking Russia from the bond markets, sanctions also paradoxically capped foreign currency liabilities and imposed greater financial discipline on Kremlin-connected firms such as Rosneft. Two years later, in May 2016, Russia reentered the Eurobond markets despite warnings from Western governments to investors to stay away. Russia then turned to corporate issues, showing that it could chip away at financial sanctions.[87]

From 2014–2016, transatlantic unity in support of sanctions was surprisingly solid, with German Chancellor Angela Merkel showing striking leadership within the European Union despite Germany's history of a close economic relationship with Russia. However, cracks are evident, with opposition arising from Hungary, the Czech Republic, Greece, and Bulgaria, while Italy and others have argued against automatic extensions of sanctions.[88] German and French businesses and Finnish farmers are also increasing opposition, although it is noteworthy that EU sanctions are implemented by individual European countries, not Brussels, giving European firms greater flexibility and regulatory discretion in their Russian deals than their U.S. counterparts have had, as evidenced by Nordstream II and BP's joint ventures with Rosneft. Throughout, Russia has attempted to exploit political divisions in the West to its advantage. The rest of the West, including Japan, South Korea, and Turkey, were reluctant and either limited or absent partners in the sanctions, despite active lobbying by the Obama administration. Skirting the spirit albeit not the letter of the sanctions, Japan showed a willingness to provide financing to a new partnership with Russia's Novatek to produce liquefied natural gas in the Arctic.[89]

Facing coercive pressure against one of its own, the BRICS club stood firmly in opposition to sanctions, but unsurprisingly did not give enthusiastic support to Russian foreign policy. In March 2014, Brazil, India, China, and South Africa joined 54 other countries that abstained in the vote on the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) resolution to condemn the Russian annexation of Crimea (which passed 100:11:58). Russia had already vetoed a Western-backed UN Security Council (UNSC) resolution (13:1:1) condemning the proposed referendum in Crimea to secede from Ukraine and join Russia. In that vote, China abstained, evidently because it did not want to